

Assigned tasks vs self-organising

IS has a varied degree of assignment and self-organisation for tasks, which is very distinct from the strictly assigned nature of the work in conventional software development. This often leads to chaos, indifference, or both.

One must ensure work continues by gamifying tasks and development components. Points, badges, leaderboards, and performance graphs can be used to assess the contributions. In some teams, it may make sense for the final score to become a factor in the annual performance appraisal.

Addressing organisational challenges

Fear of resource loss

Middle management can be an impediment to IS adoption, fearing that IS may result in a disadvantage for their organisational unit, e.g., delay in non-IS project timelines due to resource diversion towards IS projects. There is also fear of not meeting goals dependent on completion of non-IS projects. Due to this, middle managers may either hinder IS adoption or be indifferent towards it. This can have an adverse impact on the IS program's success.

To allay the middle managers' fear of losing resources, companies can create a private market for IS, where organisational units can place software components 'for sale'. They can design the public market to reimburse both for providing an IS component and for contributing to it. Take care that the private markets do not hinder reuse and collaboration.

For example, the IS program at Philips implemented something similar to a private-market where the organisational units were required to pay a fee for reusing a component (<http://dx.doi.org/10.1109/MS.2008.79>).

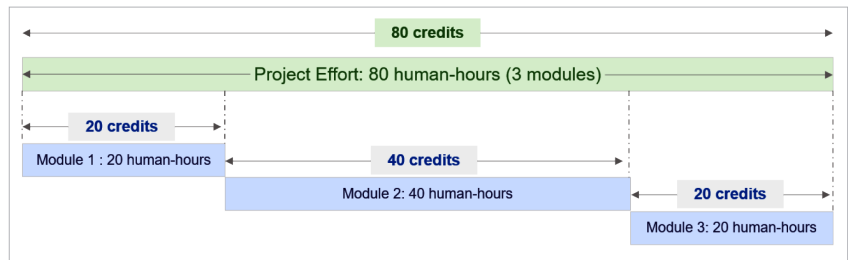


Figure 2: Division of maintenance efforts

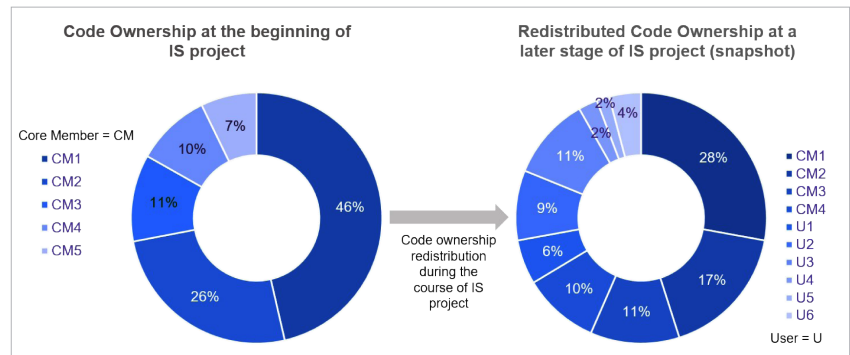


Figure 3: Code ownership structure

Perception of increased maintenance effort

Owners of an IS project usually are responsible for maintaining it. Project/module owners tend to get overburdened with maintenance activities as the number of contributions rise. Consequently, sometimes owners of IS projects are reluctant to accept contributions because they are afraid of additional maintenance effort.

To address this fear, maintenance efforts can be divided into chunks based on human-hours and credits (to be earned) can be defined for each chunk. Credits earned can be tied to performance/rewards (refer Figure 2).

Code ownership issues

In an IS setup, individuals or organisational units contribute to other organisational units' code. This can lead to code ownership conflicts between different units or between users and developers. Such conflicts can thwart IS adoption and success.

To prevent this, companies can define the code ownership like public corporation ownership. Initially, the

project shareholders (owners) are core members. Through meritocracy, further shareholding (ownership) of code depends on someone's contribution and is transferable. Figure 3 shows an example of such a code ownership structure.

Fear of not meeting performance goals

It's common for middle managers' performance goals to depend on the completion of certain tasks and projects. These managers may fear not meeting their goals because of the effort required for the team to contribute to InnerSource projects. This fear often manifests as a reluctance or hostility towards IS efforts.

To address this fear, goals can be realigned and include a component that measures contributions to the IS projects. As an example, a goal can be to dedicate 10-20 per cent of team time to IS efforts.

InnerSource brand dilution

"Success has many fathers." When an IS project succeeds, it often leads other